

Figure 4: The *Nodes* tool lets you tweak shapes

Yes, Inkscape lets you do that.

Figure 3 shows the various stages of my rendering of Dilbert. First, I drew a quadrilateral shape, roughly resembling Dilbert's head with the *Pencil* tool. To draw straight lines, use click-move-click sequences. Do not drag your mouse on the page, as it will create a curved line. Then, I selected the created shape (the quadrilateral) and chose the *Nodes* tool from the toolbar (Figure 4). This enabled me to tweak the four line segments of the quadrilateral. The bottom line segment was moved at the centre to make it curved. I then selected the top line segment and clicked the '+' toolbar icon several times to add several new nodes to the segment. This broke up the top segment into several smaller segments. I curved each of those segments to form the outline of Dilbert's hair. I also drew two straight lines of different lengths on the left side of Dilbert's face. I curved them to form Dilbert's ear. After that, I selected both lines and pressed the *Ctrl+D* key combination to duplicate

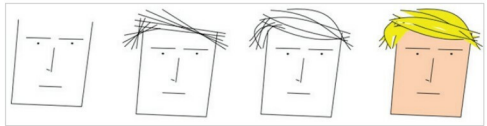


Figure 5: The Donald Trump cartoon becomes recognisable when you add colour to his trademark mop of hair

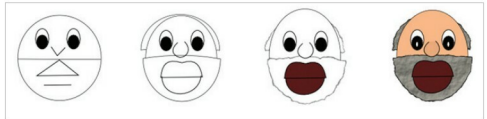


Figure 6: A caricature does not have to look like a mirror image of the person

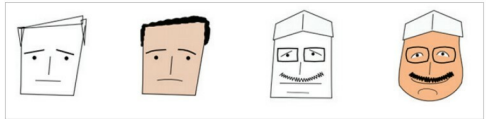


Figure 7: A caricature is identified not just by the drawing but also by the text appearing along with it

the ear. I pressed the 'H' key to flip the ear horizontally, and used arrow keys to move the new ear to the right side of Dilbert's face. The rims of Dilbert's glasses were drawn with the *Circle* tool. The folding arms of the glasses were drawn as straight lines with the *Pencil* tool. The nose was drawn with the *Circle* tool but with the 'Arc' option activated.

Figure 5 shows a Donald Trump caricature. It requires very simple lines.

The caricature in Figure 6 is more sophisticated. I drew a circle and then divided it with an arc shape using options under the *Path* drop-down menu. The top half was duplicated and reduced in height to form the hair. The bottom half was widened to make the beard. The eyes and the nose were drawn using the circle shapes. A 'filter' called 'Roughen' has been applied to the

hair at the back of the head and on the chin for a rugged outline. The hair was given a grey colour. Then, another filter called 'Rough paper' was applied to bring out the hairy texture.

A caricature is a distorted and exaggerated drawing of a person. Although your initial Inkscape drawings may not compare well against the cartoons in a mainstream newspaper or magazine, these will be good enough for a beginner. The text appearing in callouts and thought bubbles will provide the context. People will identify the real person when they read the text that accompanies your caricature.

After a few days of working with Inkscape, you can stop forwarding the funny cartoons that others send you. Instead, you can create your own. 

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